Yet, a careful distinction must be made here between art and religion. A work of art carries its significance essentially within itself. Even though, as a rule, it owes its origin to external circumstances and in consequence often awakens trains of thought moving at a tangent, still it is basically self-sufficient and requires no specific interpretation in order to be appreciated. This fact becomes most clearly evident in music, most abstract of all arts.

On the other hand, a religious symbol always points beyond itself. Its significance is never exhausted by its own features, however much veneration it may enjoy because of its own age and the operation of a pious tradition. It is important to emphasize this because the development of civilization makes the high esteem enjoyed by certain religious symbols subject to certain inevitable changes in the course of the centuries, and it is in the interest of a genuine spirit of religion to establish the fact that what stands behind and above these symbols is unaffected by such changes.

To cite here just one of a great many specific examples: A winged angel has been regarded from time immemorial as the most beautiful symbol for a servant and messenger of God. But there can be found among persons trained in anatomy, some whose scientifically conditioned imagination does not permit them, despite their best intentions, to see any beauty in such a physiological impossibility. Nevertheless, this circumstance need have not the slightest adverse effect on their religious convictions. They ought, however, to be on their guard not to impair or destroy the pious attitudes of those who still find solace and edification in the sight of a winged angel.

But the overrating of the significance of religious symbols opens the gates to another, far more serious danger of an onslaught by the atheistic movement. It is one of the favorite techniques of the atheists, whose aim is the undermining of every true religious feeling, to direct their attacks against old-established religious rites and customs and to hold them up to ridicule or contempt as outmoded anachronisms. Through such attacks against symbols, they expect to hurt religion itself, and the more strange and conspicuous those views and customs are, the easier it is for the atheists to score a success. Many a religious soul has succumbed to these tactics.

Against this peril there is no better defense than to understand clearly and thoroughly that a religious symbol, be it ever so venerable, never represents an absolute value but is always only a more or less imperfect sign of something higher and not directly accessible to human senses.

Under these circumstances, it is quite understandable that the history of religions records the frequent recurrence of the idea to restrict or even eliminate completely the use of religious symbols and to treat religion more as a matter of abstract reasoning. But even a brief reflection shows such an idea to be entirely inadequate. Without symbols, human beings could not communicate with each other at all. This applies not only to religious